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THE BIG FAT METRO PARTY

White elephants? The Bhopal and Indore Metros see paltry footfalls, get rented out for shaadis and dos

IF IT'S A METRO, IT SHOULD BE A METROPOLIS. Chew on that inverted logic, and you see the ambition that got a string of Tier-2 Indian cities buying a ticket in the past decade. But check what's happening in Bhopal and Indore. As summer rolled in, the MP Metro Rail Corporation Ltd (MPMRCL) put out word that it would rent out its metro coaches in the two cities for photo shoots for birthday parties, weddings, kitty parties and other dos.

It's not a bad offer. A stationary coach at Rs 5,000 for an hour's photo shoot. A moving one at Rs 7,000 a pop. Officials say this is aimed at familiarising the citizenry with the metro. That doesn't entirely wash—a metro ride is not bungee jumping, it's just a short train ride with air-conditioning. Just a tad costlier than usual public transport. Point is, that has proved prohibitive here—the telltale evening squeeze of humanity is nowhere in sight.

RUNNING ON EMPTY

In fact, the two metros, which began operations in the past year, have not been finding even average ridership. In Bhopal, average ridership stands at 250-300 per day; in Indore, it's even lower at 100 per day. At a time when plain-vanilla civic issues struggle for funds, people naturally wonder at the viability of mounting a white elephant.

Civic agencies say it's too early to judge, reasoning that financial viability in mass transport projects is seldom achieved soon—or ever—even in the best-run systems across the world. But the tonality has clearly been shifting: from the early days of fanfare when the BJP and Congress were both claiming credit, to defensive posturing.

The first 6 km section of the 31.2 km Indore Metro project was inaugurated on May 31, 2025. Bhopal Metro's first 7 km stretch, in a 30.8 km plan, got rocking on December 20, 2025. But post-launch, the response has been lukewarm, to say the least. Bhopal thought it wise to trim its AIIMS-to-Subhash Nagar metro frequency from nine to five. Likewise, the first free 'Joyride' week in Indore saw 150,000 denizens hop on; a graded scaling back to 75 per cent and half-rate discounts in subsequent weeks saw the enthusiasm of Indoris dip proportionately. These got only 35,000 and 15,000 takers. The trickle that the full rates attracted saw the first 15-minute inaugural frequency go down to hourly, then two-hourly, to just two round trips a day. In both cities, three 250-capacity coaches ply on each trip.

The cost overruns are nothing to sniff at. The 2018 DPR for the Bhopal Metro pegged costs at Rs 6,941 crore; that's been revised upwards to Rs 10,000 crore. Indore's Rs 7,500 crore